ASSIGNMENT

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1. Introduction

Documentary Name: "*Man in search of Man*"

Director: Prem Vaidya

Year: 1974

Location: Andaman and Nicobar Islands

Platform of Availability: YouTube

Channel: Films Division

Link: *https://youtu.be/2aJoR5d3wzs?si=K0Xx6Wh0JTecG72Y*

The documentary *"Man in Search of Man"* explores the diverse tribal cultures of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, including the Nicobarese, Great Andamanese, Shompens, Onge, Jarawa, and Sentinelese tribes. It portrays their unique beliefs, rituals, and lifestyles, such as death ceremonies, magical practices, hunting methods, and survival skills. Despite their resourcefulness and simplicity, the tribes face challenges from dwindling populations, diseases, and isolation. The narrative contrasts their primal existence with modernity, reflecting on humanity's relationship with the "untouched" Sentinelese community. The documentary raises ethical questions about preserving their culture versus assimilating them into the modern world.

❖ Why the Documentary *"Man in Search of Man"* ?

1.1. Rich Ethnographic Content: It provides in-depth insights into the lives of isolated tribal communities, making it ideal for identifying cultural, social, and behavioural patterns.

1.2. Diverse Themes: The film explores contrasting concepts such as primitivism versus modernity, superstition versus scientific knowledge, and isolation versus interaction, offering a range of phenomena to analyse.

1.3. Humanitarian Questions: It raises critical questions about preservation, assimilation, and the ethical implications of modern interventions in indigenous cultures.

1.4. Grounded Theory Alignment: The exploratory nature of the documentary aligns with Grounded Theory's goal of deriving themes and categories directly from the data without preconceived hypotheses.

2. Open Coding

Open coding is the initial step in qualitative data analysis under **Grounded Theory**, where the text is segmented into smaller units of meaning and labelled with descriptive codes. Open coding involves breaking the data into discrete parts and naming each according to its conceptual meaning. The methodology involves:

i. **Breaking Down the Documentary**: The film was divided into smaller segments, focusing on sentences or phrases with unique meanings.

ii. **Identifying Key Concepts**: Each segment was analysed for recurring patterns, concepts, and significant details.

iii. **Assigning Codes**: Labels were assigned to describe behaviours, beliefs, practices, and themes observed in the documentary.

iv. **Maintaining Criticality**: Care was taken to critically examine implicit meanings and avoid redundant or overly broad coding.

The following codes represent key themes, behaviours, beliefs, and social structures derived from the documentary.

2.1. EXPLORATION AND DISCOVERY

Uncharted Territories: "Many islands yet to be explored," "unmarked on most maps."

Expedition Purpose: "Search of the people of these remote islands."

Unknown History: "Little is known of the Champains," "We know nothing of their history."

2.2. CULTURAL BELIEFS AND PRACTICES

Superstition and Magic: "Highly superstitious," "great believers in magic," "totems."

Death Rituals: "Body exposed to the elements," "soul sails away in a boat."

Ceremonial Practices: "Food cooked in *Choda* pots for ceremonies."

Healing Practices: "Pig's blood with herbs to cure ailments," "witch doctors reign supreme."

2.3. MATERIAL CULTURE

Craftsmanship: "Famous for pottery," "good makers of boats."

Tools and Technology: "No fishing nets or lines," "concept of cooking alien."

Adaptation to Environment: "Honey gathering with special herbs," "seashell for hairdressing."

2.4. SURVIVAL AND DEPENDENCY ON NATURE

Hunter-Gatherer Lifestyle: "Women roam forests for roots and tubers," "men hunt."

Staple Diet: "Pandanus as the staple diet."

No Agriculture: "Agriculture is unknown to them."

2.5. TRIBES AND DEMOGRAPHICS

Dwindling Populations: "Champains barely 92," "Onge dwindled to 112."

Tribal Distinction: "Different origins (Negrito, Mongoloid)."

Fierce Reputation: "Jarawas are the fiercest," "Sentinelese prefer isolation."

2.6. ISOLATION AND INTERACTION

Resistance to Contact: "Sentinelese avoid strangers," "poisoned arrows."

Reception of Outsiders: "Jarawas gave a warm reception," "smiling exchanges."

Hostility vs. Curiosity: "Jarawas previously violent but now curious."

2.7. KNOWLEDGE AND IGNORANCE

Primitive Beliefs: "Mercy of their primitive beliefs."

Knowledge Gap: "We don't know their language," "glimpses of daily life only."

Missionary Influence: "Danish missionary discovered Champains."

2.8. MODERNITY VS. PRIMITIVISM

Romanticizing Primitivism: "Wonder of pagan life," "ancient hairdressing."

Modern Influence: "Tobacco popular," "alcohol unknown."

Questions of Progress: "Is the Stone Age preferable to the Nuclear Age?"

2.9. PRESERVATION VS. ASSIMILATION

Conservation Challenges: "If they don't get help, they will soon be extinct."

Gradual Assimilation: "Process of assimilation should be gradual."

2.10. HUMAN CONNECTION AND REFLECTION

Innocence and Simplicity: "Stillness and silence," "substitute for innocence."

Universal Questions: "Have we begun to understand our own impulses?"

Barriers and Breakthroughs: "Natural breaking of barriers."

2.11. MYSTERY AND UNKNOWN

Unresolved Mysteries: "Is this the first step towards understanding?"

Eternal Questions: "What are the moving shapes-are they human?"

Failed Expedition: "Expedition failed to find answers."

FINAL LIST OF CODES

1) Many islands yet to be explored
2) Unmarked on most maps.
3) Search of the people of these remote islands.
4) Little is known of the Champains,
5) We know nothing of their history.
6) Highly superstitious
7) Great believers in magic
8) Totems.
9) Body exposed to the elements
10) Soul sails away in a boat
11) Food cooked in *Choda* pots for ceremonies.
12) Pig's blood with herbs to cure ailments
13) Witch doctors reign supreme.
14) Resourcefulness without tools.
15) Famous for pottery
16) Good makers of boats.
17) No fishing nets or lines
18) Concept of cooking alien.
19) Honey gathering with special herbs
20) Seashell for hairdressing.
21) Women roam forests for roots and tubers
22) Foraging lifestyle.

23) Men hunt.

24) Pandanus as the staple diet.

25) Agriculture is unknown to them

26) Champains barely 92.

27) Onge dwindled to 112.

28) Different origins (Negrito, Mongoloid).

29) Jarawas are the fiercest.

30) Sentinelese prefer isolation.

31) Sentinelese avoid strangers.

32) Isolation as self-preservation

33) Poisoned arrows.

34) Jarawas gave a warm reception.

35) Smiling exchanges.

36) Jarawas previously violent but now curious.

37) Mercy of their primitive beliefs.

38) We don't know their language.

39) Glimpses of daily life only.

40) Danish missionary discovered Champains.

41) Wonder of pagan life.

42) Jungle symbiosis.

43) Ancient hairdressing.

44) Tobacco popular.

45) Alcohol unknown.

46) Is the Stone Age preferable to the Nuclear Age?

47) If they don't get help, they will soon be extinct.

48) Process of assimilation should be gradual.

49) Stillness and silence.

50) Substitute for innocence.

51) Have we begun to understand our own impulses?

52) Natural breaking of barriers.

53) Conflict between worlds.

54) Messages from the past.

55) Is this the first step towards understanding?

56) What are the moving shapes-are they human?

57) Expedition failed to find answers.

58) Man's search for meaning in exploration.

- **BROADER THEMES IDENTIFIED**

  i. **Cultural Preservation vs. Modernization:** The tension between protecting tribal cultures and exposing them to modern influences.
  ii. **Knowledge and Mystery:** Exploration fuelled by curiosity yet hindered by gaps in understanding.
  iii. **Environmental Symbiosis:** Dependence on and adaptation to natural surroundings.
  iv. **Ethics of Exploration:** The moral implications of disturbing isolated communities.
  v. **Resilience and Decline:** The juxtaposition of survival against the backdrop of extinction.
  vi. **Human Interconnectivity:** Questions about humanity's shared impulses and histories.

"This open coding process lays the groundwork for deeper axial coding and thematic analysis, enabling a richer understanding of the relationships between these identified codes."

3. Selective Coding

Selective coding involves identifying a core category that integrates the broader themes and specific codes into a central narrative.

3.1. CORE CATEGORY IDENTIFICATION

The **Core category**

"Cultural Resilience and Ethical Dilemmas in the Context of Modernization"

This theme gives a summary of the tension between preserving indigenous ways of life and the ethical challenges posed by external contact or modernization.

3.2. INTEGRATING SUBCATEGORIES

The subcategories derived from the open coding can be related to the core category as follows:

3.2.1. Cultural Beliefs and Practices

These highlight the tribes' unique rituals, beliefs, and adaptations to their environment, which form the core or center of their cultural strength.

E.g., "Ceremonial practices," "Superstition and magic," and "Totems."

3.2.2. Survival and Dependency on Nature

The tribes' intimate relationship with the nature emphasizes their adaptability and productiveness, critical for their flexibility in isolation.

E.g., "Hunter-gatherer lifestyle," "Staple diet," "Honey gathering with special herbs."

3.2.3. Isolation and Interaction

The tribes' selective interaction with the outside world reflects their strategies for self-preservation while negotiating the threats.

E.g., "Sentinelese avoid strangers," "Resistance to contact," "Jarawas previously violent but now curious.

3.2.4. Knowledge and Mystery

The limited understanding of these tribes highlights the gap between indigenous and external perspectives, fueling both curiosity and ethical questions.

E.g., "We don't know their language," "Unresolved mysteries," "Failed expedition."

3.2.5. Modernity vs. Primitivism

This subcategory directly ties to the core category by exploring the contrasting values of traditional lifestyles versus modernization.

E.g., "Is the Stone Age preferable to the Nuclear Age?" "Tobacco popular, alcohol unknown."

3.3. THE STORYLINE

"The Andaman and Nicobar Islands tribes are an example of unique cultural resistance that has kept their traditions intact and in harmony with nature even when their populations have decreased, and external pressures mounted. Selective isolation raises deep questions about the role of modernization in their lives. When their practices seem 'primitive,' they reflect deep human ingenuity, making us think about the common human history and the moral effects of exploration and assimilation."

4. Theoretical Coding

The purpose of Theoretical coding is to interconnect the identified categories and integrate them into a cohesive framework. The framework is then useful in developing a theory. The process uses theoretical codes to establish the connections and ensures that the theory has depth and is grounded in data. It is the final step in the grounded theory process.

4.1. EMERGING THEORY

"*Balancing Isolation and Assimilation: An Ideal Approach for Survival*"

4.2. THEORETICAL CONNECTIONS WITH CATEGORIES

Indigenous customs, such as "ceremonial practices" and "superstitious healing methods", are based on years of resilience and adaptation to their natural environment. However, modern science outright dismisses them as 'primitive'. The disparity between these two paradigms raises the question of what defines progress. Although considered unscientific, the success of tribes' epistemology challenges the notion of modern lifestyle to be superior in all terms. Instead, the lived experiences stand out as an excellent example of spirituality and sustainable life. This contest between the two stakeholders forfeits us ethically from imposing modern values and lifestyle on them.

The tribes are totally dependent on nature for all the things required for their survival. Hence, none of them have compulsive interactions with outsiders. In such a scenario, the different approaches of different tribes determine the difference in their thinking and adaptation strategies. While the Jarawas welcomed the team with a curious mind, the Sentinelese perceived them as threatening their autonomy and outright rejected any contact. Hence, the isolation level is proportional to cultural resilience, making them more vulnerable to externalities like diseases and exploitation.

The expeditions made of curiosity to learn more about these isolated tribes awakened the ethical dilemma. While most expeditions fail to answer questions about the tribes' origin, history, languages, etc., there may be exploitation cases in the guise. Thus, it is a metaphor for balancing the pursuit of knowledge with respect for the freedom and sovereignty of the subject under study.

Gradually, the "use of tobacco" shows that external influences are inevitable. However, they seriously erode the traditional practices. Hence, a balanced approach between modernity and primitivism would be to gradually assimilate them while taking utmost care to maintain their local epistemology and culture. Yet, it also questions our right to decide the best route or its pace for them. This highlights the need for more robust strategies that empower the tribes to navigate modernization by themselves.

4.3. DERIVING THE THEORY

According to this balanced approach theory, the survival of such indigenous cultures in modern times depends on a delicate equilibrium between isolation and integration. While isolation ensures the maintenance of their cultural and traditional practices, it also heightens their vulnerability to externalities like exploitation and diseases. Conversely, integration increases their chances of survival by adapting to modern systems but has the risk of losing their autonomy and identity. Ethical dilemmas with expeditions and integration efforts further complicate the situation. Modern societies must be conscious of navigating their dual roles as curious observers and potential disruptors. Ultimately, the theory calls for a respectful, balanced approach that prioritizes empowerment, autonomy, and the preservation of cultural diversity while allowing for gradual, self-directed engagement with the modern world.

This theory provides a framework for societies to engage with such isolated communities with responsibility and respect for their autonomy. It can thus be involved in future endeavors like these.

5. Politics of representation of the Audio-Visual text

The video on the Andaman and Nicobar tribes is closely associated with how we view and present others. It encompasses concepts such as selective perception, selective representation, and selective retention, all influencing our perception of these indigenous groups. Let's take this further by relating and making it more accessible.

The politics of representation is observing the "other," sharing the lens and letting these communities tell their own stories.

5.1. SELECTIVE PERCEPTION: SEEING WHAT WE WANT TO SEE

Selective perception means focusing on details that align with what we already believe or expect while ignoring others.

5.1.1. Exoticization of Tribes

The filmmakers wanted to give prominence to the "strange" practices of the tribes-such as the “Champins' use of pandanus fruit” or the “Onge's honey-gathering practices”, because the fitted the stereotypes of indigenous people as being "primitive" or "exotic." What about their in-depth knowledge of nature or their sustainable way of life? These were casually mentioned but not pursued with the same interest.

5.1.2. Mystery Vs. Reality

It frames Sentinelese's shunning of contact as a mystery, even hostility. Such a framing ignores the historical violence perpetrated by outsiders against such tribes-which is an essential context through which to understand their avoidance of contact. The expedition never engages with their reasons for avoiding contact and continues a hegemonic narrative of how tribes should respond to external expectations about interaction.

5.2. SELECTIVE REPRESENTATION: CHOOSING WHAT TO SHOW

Selective representation is about deciding which parts of the story to tell—and which to leave out.

5.2.1. Focus on Difference

The tribes are often portrayed as "others" or significantly different from modern humans. For instance, the video highlights their lack of agriculture or fishing nets but fails to elaborate on their environmental knowledge, resilience, or social structures. This creates a lopsided image that reinforces stereotypes.

5.2.2. Who Gets to Speak?

The tribes never narrate their own stories. The explorers instead interpret their lives, rituals, and beliefs. This is how they are represented through outsiders' eyes, which will hardly capture the tribes' actual experiences or values.

5.3. SELECTIVE RETENTION: REMEMBERING WHAT FITS THE NARRATIVE

Selective retention refers to remembering parts of a story that align with their existing ideas while forgetting the rest.

5.3.1. Emphasis on Primitive Life

After viewing the video, most people will retain only the description of "witch doctors," "pig's blood cures," or "stone-age" lifestyles, as these details tend to reinforce preconceived notions about tribal communities. The more complex truths about their culture, such as sustainable living or deep spiritual practices, are less likely to stick because they do not fit the dominant narrative.

5.3.2. Romanticization of Simplicity

The video romanticizes tribal life as peaceful and idyllic, with moments like the Onge's "beauty of stillness." While this might seem optimistic, it overshadows their struggles, such as diseases or the effects of external interference, which are equally essential to remember.

5.3.3. Connecting to the Politics of Representation

These selective choices—what we see, show, and remember—are not accidents. They reflect the hegemonic power dynamics that are at play. Coming from a dominant culture, the filmmakers and explorers can decide how to portray the tribes.

5.3.4. Subjectivity and Power

The lens of the outsiders shapes the video's narrative, making the tribes "less advanced" or "mysterious." Thus, modernity is established as superior, and tribes are a relic of the past.

5.3.5. Objectivity vs. Bias

Even while aiming to be objective, presenting the rituals or mundane daily life is often presented within the context of a 'fascination' towards the 'otherness.' For instance, Sentinelese's anger against outsiders as 'aggression' rather than a 'defense against exploitation' represents the element of bias.

5.3.6. Hegemony in Storytelling

This was done by portraying tribes as observers in the story, not contributors. Their existence, interpreted by the modern world outsiders, is obscured and hides control from the dominating group's control of the narrative.

5.4. HOW TO REPRESENT FAIRLY?

To overcome selective perception, representation, and retention, we need to change how we tell stories of Indigenous peoples:

5.4.1. Humanizing the Tribes

We must look upon these tribes in their entirety- as human beings, as complex, intelligent, and capable of self-determination. Let tribes speak for themselves as much as possible- respect their voice and experiences.

5.4.2. Focus on Agency

The tribes are not merely something to observe; they are communities with an agency - adjusting to their environment and making choices for themselves. For example, a refusal of contact from Sentinelese is, by definition, a manifestation of resistance, not ignorance.

5.4.3. Challenge Stereotypes

Avoid overstressing what makes them "different" and accentuate their humanity and similarities with the rest of us.

5.5. CONCLUSION: A CALL FOR ETHICAL REPRESENTATION

This documentary, although well-intentioned, illustrates the power of dynamics in representation: it prioritizes objectivity over subjectivity. It should try to elate respect for such tribes' singular lifestyles with their universal humanity, and most importantly, challenge hegemonic assumptions and advocate for the right of those tribes to define their identities and futures.